



LUKA (EXTREME LEFT) WITH USHA AND OTHER STUDENTS OF THE ACADEMY

Aspiring Athletes Kinalur, Kerala

Sprint to Success

All eyes at the 70th All India University Athletic meet at Jawaharlal Nehru Stadium, Chennai, in December were on Tintu Luka, protégé of the legendary P.T. Usha. The 20-year-old athlete representing Calicut University didn't disappoint, ending up as the queen of the meet by grabbing a gold-cum-record double in both the 800 m and 400 m races and booking her berth for the Asian Games to be held in Guangzhou, China, in November this year. She also clocked a record 2.1.92 minutes in the 800 m race, making her mentor proud. "I am grooming her to win what I missed by a whisker and become India's first woman athlete to win an Olympic medal,"

says Usha, 45, who predicts Luka will cut two seconds off her own record this year. "My dream is no different from Usha *chechi's*. I know we'll make it together," says Luka, whose father is a labourer in the Gulf. She came to Usha as a skinny 12-year-old and now she's one of 21 girls gearing up to be the Usha of tomorrow at the Usha

"I dream of winning an Olympic medal. With Usha *chechi*, I am sure I will make it through."

TINTU LUKA

Athlete

DREAM

To become a world beater in athletics and achieve what mentor P.T. Usha couldn't

School of Athletics (USHA), a seven-year-old athletic academy at Kinalur.

USHA, run by Usha and her husband Sreenivasan, a former CRPF athlete, has emerged as the country's most sought after private athletics academy. Every year, they pick a dozen 12-year-olds from Kerala and put them through a rigorous regimen. The academy has an eight-lane track, a 40-room hostel and state-of-the-art equipment. Her current dream is to have a synthetic track for the school, though her students are allowed to practise free at Infosys's Mysore campus. It's a small hurdle but it's never hindered her sprint to success in the past.

by M.G. Radhakrishnan